FUTURE PAST

ACCLAIMED CANADIAN NOVELIST **M.G. VASSANJI** MELDS HISTORY WITH FANTASY TO CREATE A POWERFUL ALLEGORY ABOUT LOVE, FAITH AND CULTURAL APPROPRIATION

The novel begins in the early 1300s, the final years of Sultan Alauddin Khilji's reign. A mysterious object has appeared, hovering high above the western horizon of imperial Delhi. Terror grips the court. The citizens, already traumatised by their despotic ruler, are rioting out of sheer panic. The narrator, a historian and poet named Amir Hassan Al-Shirazi, is commanded by the monarch to find out what he can about the apparition.

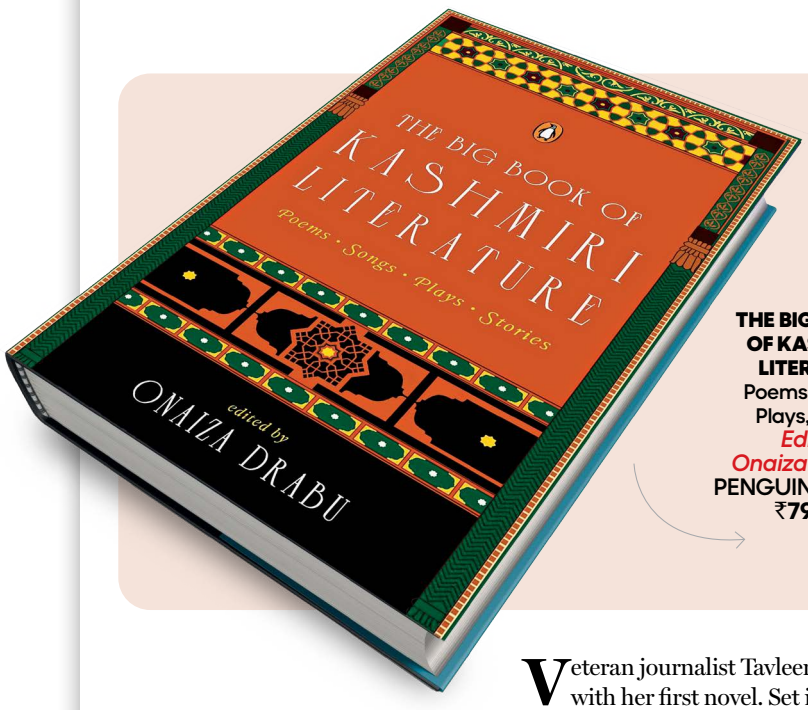
As someone of mixed Mongol-Persian ancestry, Shirazi is unusually suited to the task. He is a Muslim in public, but a Sufi at heart. His mother's renegade "Baatini" connections colour his past, while his warm friendship with local Hindus encroaches upon his present. As a scholar and linguist, he is able to communicate across the cultural spectrum of his times.

But no one can explain the sky-visitor. It cannot even be clearly described. Some see a weird cloud,

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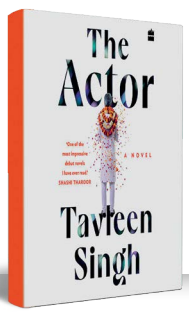
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